Check-in Calls: Volunteer Training Guide

A friendly guide for volunteers who make regular check-in phone calls. Read it before your first call, and keep the quick-reference card (last page) next to the phone.

Your organization: _____ **Coordinator:** _____ **Coordinator phone:** _____

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1. Welcome, and thank you

Thank you for giving your time. A short, warm phone call can be the highlight of someone's week. You don't need special qualifications to do this well. What matters most is that you are **kind, curious, reliable, and a good listener**.

This guide covers:

- **2.** What the program is, and what it isn't
- **3.** Why we think it helps (the evidence, briefly)
- **4.** Your role and its boundaries
- **5.** How to do a call, step by step
- **6.** Sample scripts: first call, regular call, final call
- **7.** What to avoid
- **8.** Warning signs, and what to do if you're worried (the crisis protocol)
- **9.** Confidentiality and records
- **10.** Looking after yourself
- **11.** Sources, then the quick-reference card on the last page

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2. What this program is, and what it isn't

It is:

- Regular, friendly phone calls with someone who has said they'd like more contact.
- A chance for them to talk about whatever *they* want to talk about, with someone who is genuinely interested.
- Usually a set period (often 4 to 8 weeks), on days and times that suit them.
- Run by a coordinator who supports you and handles anything beyond a friendly chat.

It is not:

- **Therapy, counselling, or medical advice.** You are a friendly voice, not a professional.
- **A crisis or emergency service.** If someone is in danger, we follow the crisis protocol (Section 8) and involve emergency services or crisis lines.
- Practical help with money, legal matters, or care. If someone needs that, you pass it to the coordinator, who can point them to the right service.
- A lifelong commitment. The calls have a clear start and end, and we prepare people for the end from the beginning.

> **Plain promise to participants:** "We're not counsellors. We're people from the community who'd like to give you a call and have a chat."

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3. Why we think this helps

Loneliness is common. The World Health Organization's Commission on Social Connection estimates that about **1 in 6 people worldwide** are lonely, and links loneliness to an estimated **871,000 deaths a year** (WHO, 2025). Lonely people are about **twice as likely to become depressed** (WHO, 2025).

The model for these calls comes from a randomized trial in Texas, USA, during 2020 (Kahlon et al., 2021):

- **240 adults** receiving Meals on Wheels services (mostly older and homebound; all had at least one long-term health condition) were randomly given either phone calls or no calls.
- **16 lay callers, aged 17 to 23,** had brief training (about an hour, by video) in **empathetic listening** and in drawing out conversation. Each caller phoned 6 to 9 people.
- Calls ran for **4 weeks**: daily for the first 5 days, then the person chose how often (at least twice a week). The **person chose the times**, and calls averaged about 10 minutes.
- After 4 weeks, the people who got calls were **less lonely, less depressed and less anxious** than those who didn't. On the 3-item UCLA Loneliness Scale they scored about 1.1 points lower (a moderate effect).

Some honest limits: that trial lasted only 4 weeks, so we don't know how long the benefit lasts. Across the wider research, loneliness programs help, but the effects are usually small to moderate (Lasgaard et al., 2026, a review of 280 studies). We think regular, warm, reliable contact is worth offering, and we measure how it goes.

What this means for you: the key ingredients are simple. Be **reliable**, **listen with empathy**, and **let the person lead**. You don't have to fix anything.

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4. Your role and its boundaries

Your role

- Call at the agreed time. If you can't, let the coordinator know as early as you can.
- Listen, show interest, and let the person steer the conversation.
- Log each call briefly in the app (or tell your coordinator, if they log calls for you).
- Notice if something seems wrong, and follow the steps in Section 8.

Boundaries that keep everyone safe

Do	Don't
Use the phone number the program gives you (or withhold your number if that's the agreed approach)	Give out your home address or personal social media
Keep calls to the agreed schedule	Promise extra calls or visits you haven't agreed with the coordinator
Pass practical requests to the coordinator	Lend or give money, buy things for them, or handle their finances
Say "I'm not able to do that, but I'll let our coordinator know"	Give medical, legal, or financial advice
Keep what they tell you confidential, within the program	Promise to keep everything secret (see Section 8)
Be yourself and share a little about your day if it helps	Make the call about you, or share your own problems at length
End calls kindly when time's up	Visit in person, unless your program has a separate, approved process for that

If you're unsure whether something is OK, **ask the coordinator**. That is always the right answer.

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5. How to do a call

A typical call is **10 to 20 minutes**. Shorter is fine. Some people love a long chat; others prefer a quick hello. Follow their lead, within the time you've agreed.

Before the call

- Find a quiet place where you won't be overheard.
- Glance at your notes from last time: what did they mention? A grandchild's visit? A doctor's appointment? A favourite TV show?
- Take a breath. Your only job is to be good company.

Step 1: Opening

- Greet them warmly and say who you are: *"Hi Margaret, it's Sam from the Friendly Calls group. Is now still a good time?"*
- Check it's still convenient. If not, agree another time and log it as rescheduled.

Step 2: Listen with empathy

Empathetic listening means trying to understand how things feel for them, and letting them know you've understood.

- **Give your full attention.** No multitasking, no screens.
- **Use small encouragers:** "Mm-hm," "Really?", "Go on…", "Oh, that's lovely."
- **Notice feelings**, not just facts: *"That sounds like it was a really long week."*

- **Allow pauses.** A few seconds of quiet is fine. People often say the important thing after a pause.

Step 3: Let them lead

In the research, callers let the person guide the conversation. That means:

- Follow the topics *they* bring up, rather than working through your own list.
- If they want to talk about the weather for ten minutes, that's a good call.
- If they want to talk about something hard, you can listen without trying to fix it.

Step 4: Ask open questions

Open questions invite more than a yes or no.

Instead of… (closed)	Try… (open)
"Did you have a good week?"	"What's your week been like?"
"Did you go out?"	"What have you been up to since we last spoke?"
"Is your garden nice?"	"Tell me about your garden. What's growing at the moment?"
"Are you OK?"	"How are you feeling about things today?"

Good conversation openers: *"What was the best bit of your week?"*, *"What did you used to do for work?"*, *"What's something you're looking forward to?"*, *"Last time you mentioned… how did that go?"*

Step 5: Reflect back

Reflecting shows you're really listening. Put what you heard into your own words:

- *"So it sounds like you really miss having people around at mealtimes."*
- *"You're feeling proud of your grandson, and a bit sad he lives so far away."*
- *"What I'm hearing is that the hospital visit was more tiring than you expected."*

If you get it slightly wrong, that's fine. They'll correct you, and the conversation keeps going.

Step 6: Closing

- Give a gentle signal a minute or two before the end: *"I'll need to go in a few minutes, but before I do…"*
- Mention something you enjoyed: *"I loved hearing about your trip to the coast."*
- End warmly: *"It's been really nice talking to you."*

Step 7: Schedule the next call

- Confirm the next call: *"Shall I call you again on Thursday at about half past ten?"*
- If they want to change the day or time, say yes if you can, or tell them you'll check with the coordinator.
- Remind them of the number of calls left as the end approaches (see the final-call script).

After the call

Log it in the app within the same day: outcome, rough length, a mood check (how they seemed, 1 to 5), a line or two of notes, and whether there's any concern. Keep notes **short, factual and kind**. Write only what you'd be comfortable with them reading.

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6. Sample call scripts

These are guides, not things to read word for word. Use your own natural words.

First call

> "Hello, is that Rosa? Hi Rosa, my name's Priya. I'm a volunteer with the Friendly Calls group. I think [coordinator] mentioned I'd be calling. Is now still a good time for a chat?
>
> Lovely. So, just so you know how this works: I'll give you a call [twice a week] for the next [four] weeks, at a time that suits you. It's just a chance to chat about whatever you like. I'm not a counsellor or anything like that, just someone who enjoys a good conversation.
>
> One thing I should mention: what you tell me stays within our small team. The only time I'd need to share something is if I was worried about your safety, and I'd try to talk to you about it first.
>
> So, tell me a bit about yourself. How long have you lived in [area]?
>
> *(...listen, follow their lead, reflect...)*
>
> I've really enjoyed this. I'd love to call again. Would [Wednesday at 2] still work for you? Great. Is there anything that would make these calls better for you, like a better time of day, or if I should call a bit louder? Lovely. Take care, Rosa, and speak to you on Wednesday."

Regular call

> "Hi Ade, it's Sam. How are you doing today?
>
> Last time you mentioned the match on Saturday. How did it go?
>
> *(...listen...)* You sound really pleased about that!
>
> What else has been happening this week?
>
> *(...listen, open questions, reflect...)* It sounds like the new flat is starting to feel more like home.
>
> I'll have to go in a minute or two, but before I do, is there anything else on your mind?
>
> Great talking to you as always. Same time on Friday? Brilliant. Take care."

If they don't answer

- Let it ring for a good while (some people take time to reach the phone).
- If your program allows voicemail: *"Hi, it's Sam from Friendly Calls, just calling for our chat. No need to call back. I'll try again [time]. Take care."*
- Log it as "No answer."

- **If you can't reach them for two scheduled calls in a row, tell the coordinator.** If you were already worried about them, tell the coordinator straight away.

Final call

Prepare for the end from about two calls before: *"Just a reminder, we've got two more calls together before the program finishes."*

> "Hi Margaret, it's Sam. So, this is our last call in this program. I've really enjoyed our chats, especially hearing about your garden and your grandchildren.
>
> How have you found the calls?
>
> *(...listen...)*
>
> [Coordinator] will be in touch about what's next. That might include [other local groups, a library club, or another round of calls, depending on what your program offers]. Is there anything you'd like me to pass on to them?
>
> *(If the program uses the short loneliness questions, the coordinator or you may ask them now.)*
>
> Thank you for letting me call. Take good care of yourself, Margaret."

Don't promise to stay in touch privately. If they ask, say: *"I'd love that, but I'm not allowed to under the program rules. I'll make sure [coordinator] knows you'd like more calls."*

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7. What to avoid

Avoid	Why	Instead
Giving advice ("You should...", "Have you tried...?")	It can feel like you're not listening, and it may be wrong for them	Reflect and ask: *"What do you think might help?"*
Promising secrecy ("I won't tell anyone")	You may need to share a safety concern	*"This stays within our small team, unless I'm worried about your safety."*
Judging ("You shouldn't feel like that")	It shuts people down	*"It makes sense that you'd feel that way."*
Fixing or rushing to cheer up ("Look on the bright side!")	It can make people feel unheard	Stay with the feeling for a moment: *"That sounds really hard."*
Interrogating (lots of questions in a row)	It feels like a form, not a chat	One question, then really listen
Talking about yourself too much	The call is for them	Share a little if it helps the conversation flow, then turn it back
Politics, religion, money disputes (unless they raise it and it stays friendly)	Can cause upset	Gently steer: *"Let's not get into that one! Tell me about..."*
Making promises you can't keep	Breaks trust	*"I'm not sure, but I'll ask the coordinator."*

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8. Warning signs, and what to do if you're worried

Most calls are simply pleasant. But sometimes you may hear something that worries you. **You are not expected to handle it alone.** Your job is to stay calm, keep them as safe as you can in the moment, and pass it on.

Warning signs to notice

Possible risk of suicide or self-harm (especially if new or getting worse):

- Talking about wanting to die, or not wanting to be here
- Saying they feel hopeless, trapped, or like a burden on others
- Saying goodbye, giving things away, or "putting affairs in order" in a way that worries you
- Talking about a plan, or having the means (pills, weapons)
- Drinking or using drugs more, withdrawing from everyone, or big mood swings

Other concerns:

- A fall, injury, or sudden illness; confusion that's new or much worse
- Not eating, no heating, no medication, or unable to look after themselves

- Signs that someone may be harming, neglecting, scaring or taking money from them
- Repeatedly not answering when they usually do

The crisis protocol

1. Immediate danger to life (they've taken something, are seriously injured, are about to harm themselves or someone else, or someone is harming them right now):

- **Call emergency services now** (for example 911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 across the EU), or ask someone near you to call while you stay on the line.
- Give their name, address and what's happening. Stay on the phone with them if you can.
- Then **tell the coordinator immediately.**

2. They talk about suicidal thoughts, but are not in immediate danger:

- **Stay calm and stay with them.** Keep your voice gentle.
- **It's OK to ask directly.** Crisis services advise being direct: *"Are you thinking about ending your life?"* (988 Lifeline). Asking shows you care and that it's OK to talk.
- **Listen without judging.** Don't argue, lecture, or act shocked.
- **Help them connect to a crisis line** now: encourage them to call, or offer to help make the call. Examples: **988** in the US (call or text), **Samaritans on 116 123** in the UK and Ireland. For other countries, see **findahelpline.com**. Your coordinator will add local numbers to the app and to the card at the end of this guide.
- **Don't promise to keep it secret.** *"I care about you, and I need to let [coordinator] know so we can make sure you get support."*
- **Tell the coordinator immediately after the call**, even if they seem calmer.
- Mark the call as **Urgent** in the app; the crisis protocol and numbers will appear on screen.

3. A non-urgent concern (they seem lower than usual, mention money worries, need practical help, missed two calls in a row, something just doesn't feel right):

- **Log it as "Follow-up needed"** with a short, factual note.
- **Make sure the coordinator knows within 24 hours.**

> **If in doubt, treat it as more serious, and tell the coordinator.** You will never be in trouble for raising a concern.

The 988 Lifeline describes five action steps for helping someone who may be at risk: **Ask, Be there, Help keep them safe, Help them connect, Follow up.** Your part is the first four, in the moment; the coordinator leads the follow-up.

After a difficult call

Write down what was said and what you did, with times, while it's fresh. Stick to facts. Then talk to the coordinator: not just to report it, but so *you* are supported too (see Section 10).

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9. Confidentiality and data

- **What they tell you stays within the program team** (you and the coordinator). Don't share names or stories with friends or family, or online, even without names if they could be recognised.
- **The exception is safety.** If you're worried someone is at risk of harm, you must share that with the coordinator (and emergency services if needed). Explain this kindly at the first call.
- **Keep records brief and factual.** Write as if the person might read it.
- **Protect devices.** If you use the app or keep notes, use a device with a password or PIN, lock it when you step away, and don't leave notes where others can see them. The app stores data only on the device it's used on.
- **Never record calls.**
- **When you leave the program**, hand back or delete any notes and participant contact details, as the coordinator asks.

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10. Looking after yourself

Listening is rewarding, and sometimes it's heavy. Looking after yourself is part of the role.

- **It's not your job to fix things.** Being there is enough.
- **You can't make someone less lonely on your own.** You're one part of their week.
- **Debrief.** After a hard call, talk to the coordinator. You can share the feeling without sharing details outside the team.
- **Notice your own signs:** dreading calls, thinking about a participant a lot, trouble sleeping. Tell the coordinator; it's OK to take a break or reduce your calls.
- **Keep to your hours.** Don't take on more than you agreed.
- **If a call brings up something painful for you**, you can use the same crisis lines too. They're for anyone.

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11. Sources

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- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. Help Someone Else. https://988lifeline.org/help-someone-else/
- Samaritans (UK & Ireland, 116 123): https://www.samaritans.org/ · Find A Helpline (international directory): https://findahelpline.com

Quick-reference card

Check-in Calls: keep this by the phone

Coordinator: _____ **Phone:** _____

Every call

1. **Open:** "Hi, it's ___ from ___. Is now still a good time?"
2. **Listen:** full attention, small encouragers, allow pauses.
3. **Let them lead:** follow *their* topics.
4. **Open questions:** "What's your week been like?" "Tell me about..."
5. **Reflect:** "It sounds like..." "So you're feeling..."
6. **Close warmly:** "I've really enjoyed this."
7. **Next call:** "Same time Thursday?"
8. **Log it** the same day: outcome, mood 1–5, short notes, any concern.

Avoid: advice-giving · promising secrecy · judging · rushing to cheer up · promises you can't keep · sharing your address · money.

Say instead: "What do you think might help?" · "This stays within our team, unless I'm worried about your safety." · "I'll ask the coordinator."

IF YOU'RE WORRIED

Immediate danger to life → call **emergency services** now (911 / 999 / 112 / local: _____). Stay on the line. Then tell the coordinator.

Suicidal thoughts → stay calm, stay with them, ask directly, listen. Help them contact a **crisis line**. Don't promise secrecy. **Tell the coordinator immediately.** Log as **Urgent**.

Non-urgent concern (low mood, practical need, 2 missed calls) → log as **Follow-up needed**. **Tell the coordinator within 24 hours.**

Crisis lines: US **988** (call/text) · UK & Ireland Samaritans **116 123** · Other countries: **findahelpline.com** · Local: _____

You're a friendly voice, not a counsellor. You don't have to fix anything. If in doubt, tell the coordinator.